

nation can be great whose people are narrow in thought.”

THE ARCHITECT

Each day over a billion Indian govern themselves in a pluralist democracy, testimony to the ideals of India's first prime minister, who steered the nation's destiny for the first 17 years

■ By Shashi Tharoor

For the first 17 years of India's Independence, the paradox-ridden Jawaharlal Nehru—a moody, idealist intellectual who felt an almost mystical empathy with the toiling peasant masses; an aristocrat, accustomed to privilege, who had passionate socialist convictions; an Anglicised product of Harrow and Cambridge who spent over 10 years in British jails; an agnostic radical who became an unlikely protégé of the saintly Mahatma Gandhi—*was* India. Upon Gandhi's assassination, Nehru became the keeper of the national flame, the most visible embodiment of India's struggle for freedom. Incorruptible, visionary, ecumenical, a politician above politics, Nehru's stature was so great that the country he led seemed inconceivable without him. A year before his death, a leading American journalist published a book entitled *After Nehru, Who?* The unspoken question around the world was: “After Nehru, what?”

Today, more than four decades after his death, we have something of an answer to the latter question. As an India still seemingly clad in the trappings of Nehruvianism steps out into the 21st century, little of Nehru's legacy appears intact. India has moved away from much of it, and so (in different ways) has the rest of the developing world for which Nehruvianism once spoke. As India begins the seventh decade of its Independence from the British Raj, a

transformation—still incomplete—has taken place that, in its essentials, has changed the basic Nehruvian assumptions of post-colonial nationhood.

The principal pillars of Nehru's legacy to India—democratic institution-building, staunch pan-Indian secularism, socialist economics at home and a foreign policy of non-alignment—were integral to a vision of Indianness that sustained India for decades, but is contested today.

Nehruvian secularism is challenged today by those who see it as a Westernised affectation that denies India's Hindu heritage. But Nehru was steeped in the composite Hindu-Muslim culture of north India, and his secularism was authentically rooted in millennial Indian traditions of tolerance for different ways of being.

His socialism seems dated today, a product of Fabian ideas long discredited by decades of failure in practice. But even if he ushered in the licence-permit-quota Raj that India is dismantling today, Nehru built much of the infrastructure in science and engineering that has provided the platform for India's IT revolution of the 1990s.

Nehru developed a role for India in the world based almost entirely on its civilisational history and moral standing, making it the voice of the oppressed and the marginalised. This gave the country enormous prestige across the world for some years, but the humiliation of the 1962 war with China demonstrated its crippling limitations. Nehru died a broken man, his spirit shattered.

Democracy remains Nehru's most enduring contribution to India. Gandhi's death could have led a lesser man to assume untrammelled power. Instead, he spent a lifetime trying to instill the habits of democracy in his people—a disdain for dictators, a respect for parliamentary procedures, an abiding faith in the constitutional system. He himself was such a convinced democrat that, at the crest of his rise, he authored an anonymous article warning Indians of the dangers of giving dictatorial temptations to Nehru. “He must be checked,” he wrote of himself. “We want no Caesars.” During his 17 years as prime minister, democratic values became so entrenched that when his daughter Indira suspended India's freedoms with a state of Emergency for 21 months, she felt compelled to return to the people for vindication, held an election, and lost it.

Nehru was that rare kind of leader who is not diminished by the inadequacies of his followers, let alone his own limitations. The American editor Norman Cousins once asked Nehru what he hoped his legacy to India would be. “Four hundred million people capable of governing themselves,” Nehru replied. The numbers have grown, but the very fact that each day over a billion Indians govern themselves in a pluralist democracy is testimony to the deeds and words of this extraordinary man.

The writer has authored the book Nehru: The Invention of India